

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Central Asia, Eurasia and Connectivity - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Central Asia, Eurasia and Connectivity	
REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST	
01	FOUNDATION — WHAT THE EURASIAN OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated
02	FOUNDATION — THE FIVE REPUBLICS AND THE BROAD-BASED POLICY OF 2012 Evidence chain: The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia
03	FOUNDATION — MULTILATERAL CHANNELS AND THE PROPOSED ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION Evidence chain: Multilateral channel use and the proposed
04	CORE — THE ENERGY INTEREST AND THE TWO-ROUTE GEOGRAPHY PROBLEM Evidence chain: Energy and resources as the substantive interest - The
05	CORE — SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION MEMBERSHIP TIERS AS THEY Evidence chain: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers
06	CORE — THE TIANJIN SUMMIT AND THE CURRENT CHAIRMANSHIP Evidence chain: The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship
07	CORE — THE DEDICATED INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT AND DIALOGUE FORMAT The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January
08	CORE — THE CHABAHAR CONTRACT AS THE CONCRETE CONNECTIVITY INSTRUMENT Evidence chain: The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity
09	CORE — THE REVOKED WAIVER AS THIRD-PARTY SANCTIONS EXPOSURE Evidence chain: The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions
10	CORE — CORRIDOR STATUS AND THE TRANSIT-RULES FRAMEWORK Evidence chain: The corridor instruments and their exact completion
11	CORE — THE DATED BILATERAL RECORD INSIDE THE REGION Evidence chain: The dated bilateral record inside the region Qualified
12	CORE — THE NEW GREAT GAME AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY The framing describes multi-actor competition and never Indian
13	CORE SYNTHESIS — PLATFORM WITHOUT PRIVILEGED ACCESS AND THE CASE FOR Evidence chain: Membership without privileged access - Cooperative
14	CORE SYNTHESIS — AFGHANISTAN'S DOUBLE ROLE AND THE SUBSTITUTED DEPENDENCY The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan
15	CORE SYNTHESIS — HONEST QUESTION OWNERSHIP FOR THIS EURASIAN OWNER (10 marks, 150 words) — this is the anchor PYQ for this topic. D A

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which statement correctly identifies What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. B. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. C. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. D. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

Answer: A. Explanation: This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q2. Which card should be filed under What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed in an International Relations answer?

A. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. B. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. C. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. D. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred.

Answer: B. Explanation: This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the

connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. D. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

Answer: C. Explanation: This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What this Eurasian owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the

nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: D. Explanation: This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q5. Which statement correctly identifies The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy?

A. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

Answer: A. Explanation: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q6. Which card should be filed under The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy in an International Relations answer?

A. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. B. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because

reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. C. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. D. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Answer: B. Explanation: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy?

A. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. B. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. C. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. D. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The five Republics and the Connect Central Asia Policy?

A. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. B. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: D. Explanation: The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q9. Which statement correctly identifies Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and

would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: A. Explanation: India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q10. Which card should be filed under Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument in an International Relations answer?

A. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. B. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: B. Explanation: India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument?

A. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. B. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and

dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: C. Explanation: India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Multilateral channel use and the proposed economic-integration instrument?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred.

Answer: D. Explanation: India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. The remaining options belong to

Q13. Which statement correctly identifies The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status?

A. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. B. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. C. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: A. Explanation: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q14. Which card should be filed under The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status in an International Relations answer?

A. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. B. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai

Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: B. Explanation: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. C. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. D. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.

Answer: C. Explanation: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and its exact status?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. C. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. D. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

Answer: D. Explanation: The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q17. Which statement correctly identifies Energy and resources as the substantive interest?

A. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. B. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the

owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: A. Explanation: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q18. Which card should be filed under Energy and resources as the substantive interest in an International Relations answer?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: B. Explanation: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Energy and resources as the substantive interest?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had

been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: C. Explanation: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Energy and resources as the substantive interest?

A. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. B. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. C. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. D. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Answer: D. Explanation: India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q21. Which statement correctly identifies The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint?

A. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. B. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. C. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: A. Explanation: India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q22. Which card should be filed under The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint in an International Relations answer?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. C. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's

contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. D. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

Answer: B. Explanation: India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. D. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

Answer: C. Explanation: India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The two-route geography problem as a binding structural constraint?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. C. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. D. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.

Answer: D. Explanation: India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q25. Which statement correctly identifies Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand?

A. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. D. The 2025 Heads of State

Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: A. Explanation: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q26. Which card should be filed under Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand in an International Relations answer?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. C. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. D. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

Answer: B. Explanation: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand?

A. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. D. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

Answer: C. Explanation: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership tiers as they now stand?

A. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. B. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full

members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.

Answer: D. Explanation: As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q29. Which statement correctly identifies The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship?

A. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

Answer: A. Explanation: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q30. Which card should be filed under The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship in an International Relations answer?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

Answer: B. Explanation: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship?

A. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. B. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. C. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. D. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity

corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

Answer: C. Explanation: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Tianjin summit and the current chairmanship?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.

Answer: D. Explanation: The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q33. Which statement correctly identifies The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format?

A. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar,

because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

Answer: A. Explanation: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q34. Which card should be filed under The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format in an International Relations answer?

A. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. B. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

Answer: B. Explanation: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated

format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. D. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

Answer: C. Explanation: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The dedicated India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue format?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial

access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

Answer: D. Explanation: The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q37. Which statement correctly identifies The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument?

A. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. B. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

Answer: A. Explanation: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q38. Which card should be filed under The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument in an International Relations answer?

A. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. B. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: B. Explanation: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument?

A. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is

current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: C. Explanation: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Chabahar contract as the concrete connectivity instrument?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. C. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. D. India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.

Answer: D. Explanation: India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q41. Which statement correctly identifies The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure?

A. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. D. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

Answer: A. Explanation: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q42. Which card should be filed under The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure in an International Relations answer?

A. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. B. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. C. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be

cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: B. Explanation: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: C. Explanation: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The revoked Chabahar waiver as third-party sanctions exposure?

A. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. C. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. D. The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.

Answer: D. Explanation: The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q45. Which statement correctly identifies The corridor instruments and their exact completion status?

A. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. B. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. C. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. D. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing

great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

Answer: A. Explanation: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q46. Which card should be filed under The corridor instruments and their exact completion status in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. B. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. C. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: B. Explanation: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The corridor instruments and their exact completion status?

A. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: C. Explanation: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The corridor instruments and their exact completion status?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. C. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. D. The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag

announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.

Answer: D. Explanation: The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q49. Which statement correctly identifies The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework?

A. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. B. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. C. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q50. Which card should be filed under The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework in an International Relations answer?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February

2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. C. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. D. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. C. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an

infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Ashgabat Agreement as a transit-rules framework?

A. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q53. Which statement correctly identifies The dated bilateral record inside the region?

A. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create

physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. D. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q54. Which card should be filed under The dated bilateral record inside the region in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. B. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The dated bilateral record inside the region?

A. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. C. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The dated bilateral record inside the region?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a

general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q57. Which statement correctly identifies The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism?

A. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q58. Which card should be filed under The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism in an International Relations answer?

A. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. B. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. C. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. D. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined

by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The New Great Game as multi-actor competition without Indian determinism?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. D. Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's

effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q61. Which statement correctly identifies Membership without privileged access?

A. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. B. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. D. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

Answer: A. Explanation: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q62. Which card should be filed under Membership without privileged access in an International Relations answer?

A. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. B. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and

India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Answer: B. Explanation: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Membership without privileged access?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: C. Explanation: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the

owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Membership without privileged access?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. C. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. D. India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

Answer: D. Explanation: India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q65. Which statement correctly identifies Cooperative management of a shared external dependency?

A. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

B. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q66. Which card should be filed under Cooperative management of a shared external dependency in an International Relations answer?

A. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

B. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair

this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. D. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Cooperative management of a shared external dependency?

A. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. B. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. C. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their

competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Cooperative management of a shared external dependency?

A. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. B. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. C. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. D. Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q69. Which statement correctly identifies Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier?

A. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. The audited ledgers route two

General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: A. Explanation: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q70. Which card should be filed under Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier in an International Relations answer?

A. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. B. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. C. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries

through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: B. Explanation: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. C. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: C. Explanation: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Afghanistan as simultaneously the bridge and the barrier?

A. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. B. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.

Answer: D. Explanation: Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q73. Which statement correctly identifies Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency?

A. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. B. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. C. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South

Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: A. Explanation: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q74. Which card should be filed under Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency in an International Relations answer?

A. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. B. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Answer: B. Explanation: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. C. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: C. Explanation: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Substituted dependency rather than eliminated dependency?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. C. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. D. The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

Answer: D. Explanation: The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner?

A. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. B. This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. C. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: A. Explanation: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q78. Which card should be filed under Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner in an International Relations answer?

A. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. B. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. C. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. D. The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.

Answer: B. Explanation: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner?

A. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. B. India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. C. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on

outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. D. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Answer: C. Explanation: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Honest question ownership for this Eurasian owner?

A. The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. B. India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one. C. India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. D. The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Answer: D. Explanation: The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

Two General Studies Paper II Mains demands are routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and each is reproduced below as a demand card with its printed year, paper, question number, directive, marks and word limit exactly as the ledger records them: 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words, for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership; and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words. One objective demand is also routed to this owner and is carried as a coverage requirement only: 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally. No option or answer letter is recorded or inferred for that objective demand, and the presence of a locally held key is not treated as permission to publish one. Where a printed word limit or stem tail is recorded as corrupted in the scan, that defect is reported rather than silently repaired by invented wording. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of the routed Mains demands; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or official answer key was imported.

OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

9. PYQ application

- **FACT: 2024 Q10 (direct):** *Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics.* **Structure:** (1) list the five CARs and the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012); (2) cite the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement and SCO engagement as the "evolving" economic/diplomatic dimension; (3) name the Afghanistan/Pakistan connectivity constraint and the Xinjiang/Karakoram alternative-route problem as the "critical" analytical dimension; (4) place the relationship within the "New Great Game" great-power-competition context to address "increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics."

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2024-2025.md, _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2024-2025.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2024-2025 Prelims Set-A keys are present in the repository and CSAT Set-A keys are supplied; even so, no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Years represented:** 2024, 2025
- **Paper(s):** GS-II, Prelims GS-I

- Routed question demands: 2

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2024	GS-II	10	India's relations with the Central Asian Republics	Critically analyse · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2025	Prelims GS-I	62	International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) connectivity	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- India's relations with the Central Asian Republics
- International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) connectivity

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2018	GS-II	10	Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement	Discuss the implications · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- **FACT: 2024 Q10 (direct):** *Critically analyse India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics (CARs) highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics.* An advanced answer should:

1. Name the Connect Central Asia Policy (2012) and SCO engagement as the diplomatic/economic evolution.
2. Identify the structural connectivity constraint (no direct land access; Xinjiang/Karakoram alternative equally constrained) as the critical limiting factor.
3. Discuss INSTC/Chabahar as a partial, Iran-dependent work-around.
4. Place the analysis within the "New Great Game" competitive context, explicitly noting that outcomes are co-determined by Russia, China and Western engagement, not by India alone.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2018
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2018	GS-II	10	Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement	Discuss the implications · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic; printed word-limit tail OCR-corrupted in scan	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2018 General Studies Paper II Question 10

Demand: Outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger. The ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan, and that defect is reported here rather than repaired by invented wording.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed, and no reconstruction of the corrupted word-limit tail is attempted.

Model solution: Claim: joining the Ashgabat Agreement matters less as a transport decision than as India's attempt to acquire a rules-based transit right in a region where outside powers already hold geographic and historical advantage. Named evidence and example: the Agreement signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, which India joined with effect from 3 February 2018; the absence of direct land access to Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between; Sikri's finding that any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges; the International North-South Transport Corridor and Chabahar port as the maritime-linked work-around; and Sikri's New Great Game framing of a region that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences. Analysis: accession converts an aspiration into a transit framework that reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan, and it complements rather than duplicates the corridor projects, because a rules framework governs movement while a port and a corridor supply the physical route; the implication for outside-power competition is that India substitutes institutional participation for the geographic proximity that Russia and China already possess, which is the only lever genuinely available to a state without a land border in the region. Qualification: the Agreement is a facilitation framework and not an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure; the outcome in the region is co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement rather than by India's effort alone; and Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership, whose current tiers place Pakistan and Iran as full members, provides a platform without resolving transit access. Why this earns marks: it discusses implications rather than describing the Agreement, dates both the instrument and India's accession, and names the exact limit that separates a transit framework from delivered connectivity.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2018 General Studies Paper II Question 10", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints,

objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: joining the Ashgabat Agreement matters less as a transport decision than as India's attempt to acquire a rules-based transit right in a region where outside powers already hold geographic and historical advantage. Named evidence and example: the Agreement signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, which India joined with effect from 3 February 2018; the absence of direct land access to Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between; Sikri's finding that any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges; the International North-South Transport Corridor and Chabahar port as the maritime-linked work-around; and Sikri's New Great Game framing of a region that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences. Analysis: accession converts an aspiration into a transit framework that reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan, and it complements rather than duplicates the corridor projects, because a rules framework governs movement while a port and a corridor supply the physical route; the implication for outside-power competition is that India substitutes institutional participation for the geographic proximity that Russia and China already possess, which is the only lever genuinely available to a state without a land border in the region. Qualification: the Agreement is a facilitation framework and not an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure; the outcome in the region is co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement rather than by India's effort alone; and Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership, whose current tiers place Pakistan and Iran as full members, provides a platform without resolving transit access. Why this earns marks: it discusses implications rather than describing the Agreement, dates both the instrument and India's accession, and names the exact limit that separates a transit framework from delivered connectivity.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2018 General Studies Paper II Question 10 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: joining the Ashgabat Agreement matters less as a transport decision than as India's attempt to acquire a rules-based transit right in a region where outside powers already hold geographic and historical advantage. Named evidence and example: the Agreement signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, which India joined with effect from 3 February 2018; the absence of direct land access to Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between; Sikri's finding that any Eurasia-to-India pipeline avoiding Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges; the International North-South Transport Corridor and Chabahar port as the maritime-linked work-around; and Sikri's New Great Game framing of a region that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences. Analysis: accession converts an aspiration into a transit framework that reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan, and it complements rather than duplicates the corridor projects, because a rules framework governs movement while a port and a corridor supply the physical route; the implication for outside-power competition is that India substitutes institutional participation for the geographic proximity that Russia and China already possess, which is the only lever genuinely available to a state without a land border in the region. Qualification: the Agreement is a facilitation framework and not an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure; the outcome in the region is co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement rather than by India's effort alone; and Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership,

whose current tiers place Pakistan and Iran as full members, provides a platform without resolving transit access. Why this earns marks: it discusses implications rather than describing the Agreement, dates both the instrument and India's accession, and names the exact limit that separates a transit framework from delivered connectivity.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2018 General Studies Paper II Question 10", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 10

Demand: India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics, highlighting their increasing significance in regional and global geopolitics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger and reproduced in the Basic owner as the anchor demand for this topic. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the relationship has genuinely evolved across diplomatic, economic and strategic limbs, but its increasing significance must be assessed critically against a connectivity constraint that none of the evolution has yet removed. Named evidence and example: the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 as a broad-based approach covering political, security, economic and cultural connections with Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan; the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation that formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg with a second round in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the first India-Central Asia Summit held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and the third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and National Security Advisers at Bishkek on 16 October 2025; India's full Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership alongside the summit at Tianjin of 31 August and 1 September 2025 that adopted the Tianjin Declaration; the Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief current as on April 2026; and the connectivity instruments of Chabahar, contracted for ten years on 13 May 2024, the Ashgabat Agreement joined from 3 February 2018 and the International North-South Transport Corridor. Analysis: the diplomatic limb has institutionalised at ministerial and security-adviser level, the economic limb has moved from proposal to a live negotiation, and the strategic limb has acquired a maritime-linked route that bypasses Pakistan, so the direction of travel is real; yet the critical reading is that no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, the free-trade negotiation remains open, and the corridor instruments remain developing frameworks with operating segments rather than completed, full-capacity routes, so significance is rising in engagement while remaining bounded in delivery. Qualification: the analysis must place India inside the New Great Game competitive field rather than treating it as the decisive actor, must record that the revocation of the United States Chabahar sanctions waiver effective 29 September 2025 with non-exposure assurance only to 26 April 2026 creates exposure without creating a legal obligation on India, and must concede that Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership supplies a platform and not privileged access, particularly because Pakistan is also a full member. Why this earns marks: it satisfies the critical directive by pairing every claim of evolution with a dated limit, and it names the structural constraint instead of listing opportunities.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 10", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the relationship has genuinely evolved across diplomatic, economic and strategic limbs, but its increasing significance must be assessed critically against a connectivity constraint that none of the evolution has yet removed. Named evidence and example: the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 as a broad-based approach covering political, security, economic and cultural connections with Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan,

Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan; the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation that formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg with a second round in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the first India-Central Asia Summit held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and the third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and National Security Advisers at Bishkek on 16 October 2025; India's full Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership alongside the summit at Tianjin of 31 August and 1 September 2025 that adopted the Tianjin Declaration; the Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief current as on April 2026; and the connectivity instruments of Chabahar, contracted for ten years on 13 May 2024, the Ashgabat Agreement joined from 3 February 2018 and the International North-South Transport Corridor. Analysis: the diplomatic limb has institutionalised at ministerial and security-adviser level, the economic limb has moved from proposal to a live negotiation, and the strategic limb has acquired a maritime-linked route that bypasses Pakistan, so the direction of travel is real; yet the critical reading is that no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026, the free-trade negotiation remains open, and the corridor instruments remain developing frameworks with operating segments rather than completed, full-capacity routes, so significance is rising in engagement while remaining bounded in delivery. Qualification: the analysis must place India inside the New Great Game competitive field rather than treating it as the decisive actor, must record that the revocation of the United States Chabahar sanctions waiver effective 29 September 2025 with non-exposure assurance only to 26 April 2026 creates exposure without creating a legal obligation on India, and must concede that Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership supplies a platform and not privileged access, particularly because Pakistan is also a full member. Why this earns marks: it satisfies the critical directive by pairing every claim of evolution with a dated limit, and it names the structural constraint instead of listing opportunities.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 10 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger and reproduced in the Basic owner as the anchor demand for this topic. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the relationship has genuinely evolved across diplomatic, economic and strategic limbs, but its increasing significance must be assessed critically against a connectivity constraint that none of the evolution has yet removed. Named evidence and example: the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 as a broad-based approach covering political, security, economic and cultural connections with Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan; the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation that formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg with a second round in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the first India-Central Asia Summit held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and the third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and National Security Advisers at Bishkek on 16 October 2025; India's full Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership alongside the summit at Tianjin of 31 August and 1 September 2025 that adopted the Tianjin Declaration; the Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief current as on April 2026; and the connectivity instruments of Chabahar, contracted for ten years on 13 May 2024, the Ashgabat Agreement joined from 3 February 2018 and the International North-South Transport Corridor. Analysis: the diplomatic limb has institutionalised at ministerial and security-adviser level, the economic limb has moved from proposal to a live negotiation, and the strategic limb has acquired a maritime-linked route that bypasses Pakistan, so the direction of travel is real; yet the critical reading is that no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August

2026, the free-trade negotiation remains open, and the corridor instruments remain developing frameworks with operating segments rather than completed, full-capacity routes, so significance is rising in engagement while remaining bounded in delivery. Qualification: the analysis must place India inside the New Great Game competitive field rather than treating it as the decisive actor, must record that the revocation of the United States Chabahar sanctions waiver effective 29 September 2025 with non-exposure assurance only to 26 April 2026 creates exposure without creating a legal obligation on India, and must concede that Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership supplies a platform and not privileged access, particularly because Pakistan is also a full member. Why this earns marks: it satisfies the critical directive by pairing every claim of evolution with a dated limit, and it names the structural constraint instead of listing opportunities.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 10", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain why India's Central Asia connectivity problem is structural rather than merely technical. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The problem is structural because both plausible overland routes fail for different reasons at the same time, so the answer must state the absence of direct land access first, set the politically constrained route against the geographically extreme Xinjiang and Karakoram alternative, and close by showing that the maritime-linked work-around substitutes rather than removes dependence.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.
- The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement.
- Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one.
- The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space.

Qualified conclusion: The problem is structural because both plausible overland routes fail for different reasons at the same time, so the answer must state the absence of direct land access first, set the politically constrained route against the geographically extreme Xinjiang and Karakoram alternative, and close by showing that the maritime-linked

work-around substitutes rather than removes dependence.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Explain why India's Central Asia connectivity problem is structural rather than merely...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The problem is structural because both plausible overland routes fail for different reasons at the same time, so the answer must state the absence of direct land access first, set the politically constrained route against the geographically extreme Xinjiang and Karakoram alternative, and close by showing that the maritime-linked work-around substitutes rather than removes dependence.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The International North-South Transport Corridor is a connectivity framework intended to open a maritime-linked route to Central Asia and Eurasia bypassing Pakistan, and the owners require it to be treated as an announced and developing corridor with operating segments rather than a completed, full-capacity corridor; the same discipline extends to Chabahar, because connectivity-project timelines routinely lag announcements, so any specific capacity, throughput or completion claim requires independent dated verification instead of being assumed to match the original announcement. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Afghanistan sits at the centre of the connectivity problem because it is the potential land-bridge to Central Asia while being itself a source of instability that currently forecloses that option, and the owners record this as a genuine unresolved tension rather than a solved problem; the consequence for answer writing is that Afghanistan cannot be treated either as a ready corridor or as an irrelevant space, and any recommendation must be calibrated to a situation in which the shortest route is the least available one. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The maritime-linked work-around through Iran bypasses the Pakistan land constraint but substitutes one set of external dependencies, namely Iran-linked geopolitics and sanctions risk, for another, so no unilateral connectivity solution exists and the dependency problem is managed rather than removed; the owners pair this with the timeline warning that announcements outrun delivery in this sector, which together give the honest verdict that India's Central Asia problem is not an absence of interest but the conversion of diplomatic goodwill into reliable access across contested transit space. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The problem is structural because both plausible overland routes fail for different reasons at the same time, so the answer must state the absence of direct land access first, set the politically constrained route against the geographically extreme Xinjiang and Karakoram alternative, and close by showing that the maritime-linked work-around substitutes rather than removes dependence.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Explain why India's Central Asia connectivity problem is structural rather than merely...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Comment on the proposition that membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has given India privileged access to Central Asia. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The proposition fails because a mixed-membership forum cannot deliver a member-specific outcome, so the comment must state the current membership tiers exactly, name Pakistan's own membership as the reason the transit problem survives the forum, and still credit the platform value that membership genuinely provides.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted.
- The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting.
- India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.
- This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional

profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner.

Qualified conclusion: The proposition fails because a mixed-membership forum cannot deliver a member-specific outcome, so the comment must state the current membership tiers exactly, name Pakistan's own membership as the reason the transit problem survives the forum, and still credit the platform value that membership genuinely provides.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** requires a direct position on "Comment on the proposition that membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has given...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The proposition fails because a mixed-membership forum cannot deliver a member-specific outcome, so the comment must state the current membership tiers exactly, name Pakistan's own membership as the reason the transit problem survives the forum, and still credit the platform value that membership genuinely provides.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** As of 3 August 2026 the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has ten full members, namely Belarus, China, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, two observers, namely Afghanistan and Mongolia, and fifteen dialogue partners, with Pakistan a member since 2017, Iran since 2023 and Belarus since 2024, while a decision of 1 September 2025 envisages consolidating the observer and dialogue-partner categories into a single SCO Partner status whose enabling amendments had not entered into force; the owners warn expressly that Sikri's book-period note placing Pakistan, Iran and Mongolia in observer status is period-specific and must be dated whenever it is quoted. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** The 2025 Heads of State Council summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation met at Tianjin on 31 August and 1 September 2025 and adopted the Tianjin Declaration, Kyrgyzstan holds the 2025-26 chairmanship and the next summit is scheduled for Bishkek, while India's own accession to full membership in 2017 is treated as chronology owned by the World History and Polity owners; the owners permit the summit and declaration to be cited as dated evidence of India's continued multilateral engagement and permit no claim about the declaration's contents beyond its adoption at that meeting. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** This topic owns the five Central Asian Republics, the Connect Central Asia Policy, the India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue mechanisms, India's Central Asian use of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the connectivity instruments of the International North-South Transport Corridor, Chabahar port and the Ashgabat Agreement, the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation and the New Great Game

framing, and its distinctive feature is that its examinable spine is a constraint rather than an opportunity, because two verified General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2018 and 2024 and one objective demand from 2025 are routed here; the full institutional profile of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation belongs to topic 10, the India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03, the West Asian and energy-security limb of Chabahar belongs to topic 06, physical and route geography belongs to the Geography owner, and Soviet-era regional chronology with the nineteenth-century Great Game belongs to the World History owner. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The proposition fails because a mixed-membership forum cannot deliver a member-specific outcome, so the comment must state the current membership tiers exactly, name Pakistan's own membership as the reason the transit problem survives the forum, and still credit the platform value that membership genuinely provides.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Comment on the proposition that membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation has given...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the instruments through which India has pursued economic and institutional engagement with Central Asia, and state what each instrument has and has not achieved. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Each instrument sits at a different evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the broad-based policy of 2012 through the proposed economic agreement and its negotiation rounds to the dedicated summit and dialogue format, and must state the unheld second summit and the open negotiation honestly rather than presenting intent as outcome.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.
- India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred.
- The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as

under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force.

- The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

Qualified conclusion: Each instrument sits at a different evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the broad-based policy of 2012 through the proposed economic agreement and its negotiation rounds to the dedicated summit and dialogue format, and must state the unheld second summit and the open negotiation honestly rather than presenting intent as outcome.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the instruments through which India has pursued economic and institutional engagement...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Each instrument sits at a different evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the broad-based policy of 2012 through the proposed economic agreement and its negotiation rounds to the dedicated summit and dialogue format, and must state the unheld second summit and the open negotiation honestly rather than presenting intent as outcome.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** India engages Central Asia partly through existing fora described in the sources as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union, and it has proposed a Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement to integrate its markets with the Eurasian space; the examinable discipline is that a proposal is an instrument of intent rather than an operating arrangement, so an answer must name the proposal by its exact title and then trace what actually happened to it rather than implying that market integration has already occurred. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement is now pursued as the India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation, which formally began on 3 June 2017 at St Petersburg and remained under negotiation, with the second round held in Moscow on 22-25 June 2026; the owners fix the status precisely as under negotiation and neither signed nor in force, so an answer may cite the dated rounds as evidence of sustained economic engagement and may never assert conclusion, signature or entry into force. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official

source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Each instrument sits at a different evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the broad-based policy of 2012 through the proposed economic agreement and its negotiation rounds to the dedicated summit and dialogue format, and must state the unheld second summit and the open negotiation honestly rather than presenting intent as outcome.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the instruments through which India has pursued economic and institutional engagement...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the connectivity architecture India has built around the Pakistan transit constraint and assess how far third-party measures condition it. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: The architecture is real and dated but conditioned by another state's domestic law, so the examination must set the contract of 13 May 2024 and the Ashgabat framework against the waiver revocation effective 29 September 2025 and the assurance limit of 26 April 2026, and must distinguish exposure from obligation throughout.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests.
- The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question.
- The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with

effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure.

- India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Qualified conclusion: The architecture is real and dated but conditioned by another state's domestic law, so the examination must set the contract of 13 May 2024 and the Ashgabat framework against the waiver revocation effective 29 September 2025 and the assurance limit of 26 April 2026, and must distinguish exposure from obligation throughout.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the connectivity architecture India has built around the Pakistan transit constraint...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The architecture is real and dated but conditioned by another state's domestic law, so the examination must set the contract of 13 May 2024 and the Ashgabat framework against the waiver revocation effective 29 September 2025 and the assurance limit of 26 April 2026, and must distinguish exposure from obligation throughout.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** India Ports Global Limited and Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation signed a ten-year long-term contract for Chabahar port on 13 May 2024, with India announcing roughly one hundred and twenty million United States dollars in equipment investment and a two hundred and fifty million United States dollar credit window for mutually identified infrastructure; the owners require these to be cited as announced investment and an announced credit window rather than as delivered equipment or disbursed finance, because an announcement and a delivery are different evidentiary levels and the difference is exactly what a critical demand tests. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The United States State Department revoked the 2018 Chabahar sanctions waiver on 16 September 2025 with effect from 29 September 2025, and a subsequent assurance of non-exposure ran only to 26 April 2026, so any status beyond that date requires fresh verification; the owners state the legal character precisely, because this is a change in another state's domestic sanctions posture that creates exposure risk for entities rather than an international legal obligation binding on India, and its practical effect is to convert the Iran work-around from a geographic question into a financing and sanctions-exposure question. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The Ashgabat Agreement was signed at Ashgabat on 25 April 2011 to establish an international multimodal transport and transit corridor between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman, and India joined with effect from 3 February 2018, which adds a rules-and-transit framework to India's Chabahar and corridor strategy and reduces dependence on direct territorial access through Pakistan; the owners attach the limitation directly, because it is a facilitation framework rather than an infrastructure-finance mechanism, so its value depends on connected ports, rail and road segments, customs coordination and Iran-related sanctions exposure. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State

membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** India looks to Central Asia as a long-term partner in energy and natural resources, given the region's substantial hydrocarbon and mineral endowment, and this interest is what makes the connectivity question consequential rather than merely administrative; the owners keep the claim at the level of a stated policy interest and do not attach any volume, share, price or contract figure to it, because no such figure is carried by the sources and an invented number would convert a defensible interest claim into a fabricated one.

Analysis: Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The architecture is real and dated but conditioned by another state's domestic law, so the examination must set the contract of 13 May 2024 and the Ashgabat framework against the waiver revocation effective 29 September 2025 and the assurance limit of 26 April 2026, and must distinguish exposure from obligation throughout.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the connectivity architecture India has built around the Pakistan transit constraint...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian Republics against the constraint that shapes them. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Evolution and constraint must be assessed together, so the assessment must evidence the diplomatic, economic and security limbs with dated anchors, place them inside a competitive field that India does not control, and deliver a graded verdict on significance rather than an optimistic list of opportunities.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured.
- The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance.

- The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship.
- Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable.

Qualified conclusion: Evolution and constraint must be assessed together, so the assessment must evidence the diplomatic, economic and security limbs with dated anchors, place them inside a competitive field that India does not control, and deliver a graded verdict on significance rather than an optimistic list of opportunities.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Evolution and constraint must be assessed together, so the assessment must evidence the diplomatic, economic and security limbs with dated anchors, place them inside a competitive field that India does not control, and deliver a graded verdict on significance rather than an optimistic list of opportunities.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The five Central Asian Republics are Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, and the Connect Central Asia Policy launched in 2012 aims at strengthening and expanding India's relations with those countries through a broad-based approach including political, security, economic and cultural connections; the owners insist on the word broad-based because reducing the policy to energy alone misdescribes its declared scope, and they treat the 2012 launch as the foundational Indian policy approach against which every later mechanism in this topic is measured. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The first India-Central Asia Summit was held virtually on 27 January 2022, the fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue at foreign-minister level met in New Delhi on 6 June 2025 and envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit, and the third meeting of Secretaries of Security Councils and National Security Advisers met at Bishkek on 16 October 2025, while no second leader-level summit had been recorded as held by 3 August 2026; the owners treat that absence as a candid indicator that the dedicated format has not yet institutionalised at leader level, and they require the gap to be stated rather than glossed over when a demand asks about increasing significance. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The Ministry of External Affairs India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief is current as on April 2026 and is the authoritative dated record for that relationship, and the owners instruct that this brief be cited for any specific current claim about it rather than a general assertion of warm ties; the wider methodological point is that a region-level policy claim and a country-level status claim require different evidence, so a candidate should name the dated brief when the demand turns on the present state of a particular bilateral relationship. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership

and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri frames Central Asia as a geographical area that abuts on the borders of major powers in Asia and will always attract foreign presences, which describes ongoing great-power competition for influence rather than any Indian ability to determine regional outcomes, and the owners add that Russia's and China's greater historical and geographic proximity constrains how much relative influence India can realistically build however effective its own diplomacy; the examinable consequence is that outcomes in this region are co-determined by Russian, Chinese and Western engagement, so an answer must place India's effort inside a competitive field rather than presenting it as the decisive variable. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Evolution and constraint must be assessed together, so the assessment must evidence the diplomatic, economic and security limbs with dated anchors, place them inside a competitive field that India does not control, and deliver a graded verdict on significance rather than an optimistic list of opportunities.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess India's evolving diplomatic, economic and strategic relations with the Central Asian...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess whether functional cooperation with China is compatible with India's competitive position in Eurasia. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Compatibility depends on separating the functional issue from the strategic relationship, so the assessment must use the energy-understanding argument as the cooperative case, weigh it against the China-dependent overland route and the mixed-membership forum, and close with a calibrated recommendation that predicts no corridor completion or negotiation outcome.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership.
- India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects.

- India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time.
- The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them.

Qualified conclusion: Compatibility depends on separating the functional issue from the strategic relationship, so the assessment must use the energy-understanding argument as the cooperative case, weigh it against the China-dependent overland route and the mixed-membership forum, and close with a calibrated recommendation that predicts no corridor completion or negotiation outcome.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess whether functional cooperation with China is compatible with India's competitive...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Compatibility depends on separating the functional issue from the strategic relationship, so the assessment must use the energy-understanding argument as the cooperative case, weigh it against the China-dependent overland route and the mixed-membership forum, and close with a calibrated recommendation that predicts no corridor completion or negotiation outcome.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri argues that India must try to develop an understanding on energy with China because both are major energy consumers often seeking energy from the same sources and their competition is only benefiting the energy producers, which the owners treat as a rare explicit call for cooperative management of a shared dependency despite broader strategic mistrust; the analytical value of this anchor is that it shows competition and cooperation coexisting on a specific functional issue, so a critical answer can avoid the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** India's full membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation provides a seat and a platform but not privileged influence, because the same forum includes China, Russia and Pakistan, so its outputs reflect compromise among competing major-power interests rather than an India-centred agenda, and Pakistan's own membership means the forum cannot itself resolve the transit-access problem; the owners therefore separate two claims that answers routinely merge, namely that membership sustains political, security and economic engagement, and that membership does not by itself create physical connectivity, which depends on separate corridor projects. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** India has no direct land access to the Central Asian Republics because Pakistan and Afghanistan lie in between, so the first overland option is politically and security constrained, while Sikri records that any energy pipeline from Eurasia to India not crossing Afghanistan or Pakistan has to be routed via Xinjiang and then across the Karakoram and the Himalayan mountain ranges, which is geographically extreme and would require Chinese cooperation; the owners are categorical that this is a structural rather than a merely technical problem, so both plausible overland routes carry a serious political or geographic difficulty at the same time. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The audited ledgers route two General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, namely 2018 General Studies Paper II question 10 on outside powers in Central Asia and India joining the Ashgabat Agreement, a Discuss the implications demand of 10 marks and 150 words for which the ledger records that the printed word-limit tail was corrupted in the scan and that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership, and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 10 on India's evolving relations with the Central Asian Republics, a Critically analyse demand of 10 marks and 150 words; one objective demand is also routed here and carried as a coverage requirement only, namely 2025 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 62 on International North-South Transport Corridor connectivity, for which the official Set-A key is present locally while no option or answer letter is recorded or inferred; the locally held OCR-searchable official papers were read only to confirm printed wording and no question, key or marking scheme was imported from them. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Compatibility depends on separating the functional issue from the strategic relationship, so the assessment must use the energy-understanding argument as the cooperative case, weigh it against the China-dependent overland route and the mixed-membership forum, and close with a calibrated recommendation that predicts no corridor completion or negotiation outcome.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess whether functional cooperation with China is compatible with India's competitive...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.